

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 975

By Jones J

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Gloria McKissack of Nashville.

WHEREAS, it is our privilege to honor an iconic veteran of the Civil Rights Movement who has worked tirelessly to advance racial justice in Tennessee and across our nation; and

WHEREAS, such an esteemed individual is Gloria McKissack of Nashville, a veteran civil rights activist, educator, and lifelong advocate for justice whose faith has been lived out through courageous action; and

WHEREAS, born in Detroit, Michigan, on August 31, 1943, Gloria McKissack graduated from Central High School before deciding to enroll at a southern HBCU (Historically Black Colleges and Universities), Tennessee A&I College, now Tennessee State University, instead of accepting a scholarship to Wayne State University, which was then predominantly white; and

WHEREAS, as a student at Tennessee State University, she participated in the Nashville Sit-In Movement and joined SNCC, the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee, risking her life to dismantle segregation; and

WHEREAS, at that time, in 1960, the Freedom Rides had taken place, and Greensboro, North Carolina, had started a sit-in movement; Gloria McKissack almost immediately became an active participant in the Nashville Sit-In Movement, and she did not hesitate when recruited by expelled Freedom Riders to join the Student Non-Violent Coordinating Committee; and

WHEREAS, SNCC students, under the leadership of future Congressman John Lewis, risked their education and their lives to end discrimination, not only at lunch counters but restaurants, hotels, public parks, theaters, and places of employment; and

WHEREAS, Ms. McKissack still suffers from a back injury that she incurred when a brick was thrown at her and others seeking safety at First Baptist Church, Capitol Hill; and

WHEREAS, a lifelong educator and activist, Gloria McKissack continues to share her firsthand experiences from the Civil Rights Movement, her early days as an instructor as schools were being integrated, and the features of today's movement that give her hope for the future; and

WHEREAS, it is most appropriate that we pay respectful tribute to this trailblazing hero of the Civil Rights Movement in Tennessee and our nation; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Gloria McKissack, an outstanding and inspirational leader for social justice and human rights, for her unwavering commitment to nonviolence and her lifelong service to our State and our country.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.